

Is there a set of generic evaluation questions you can use to evaluate any organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative?

The first stage in evaluating 'What Works' is to identify the set of evaluation questions that need to be answered in regard to any organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative.

Usually, people attempt to develop such a list of evaluation questions from scratch. These lists can sometimes be confusing when questions in the list overlap with each other. It can also be hard to determine whether the list covers all of the important evaluation questions that you could potentially ask about a particular organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative if you want to optimize its implementation and prove that it works.

You can use this Generic Evaluation Questions List (G6) as the starting point for any evaluation planning for any initiative in any sector. To use it, you select those questions that you want answered in the case of the particular initiative you want to evaluate. If you wish, you can change the wording of some or all of the questions to make them more specific to the evaluation you are working on. For instance, in Question 8, which is concerned with impact evaluation, you could include the specific outcomes you want to be examined relating to the particular organization, agency, provider, policy or initiative you are evaluating (see Defining an Initiative's Outcomes (B13)).

This tool can also be used to review whether a list of proposed evaluation questions is comprehensive. To do this, take each question in the proposed list of evaluation questions that you are assessing and identify which of the questions in this tool it focuses on. You can then work out if there are any gaps or overlaps in the list of evaluation questions that you are reviewing. You can do this in conjunction with the Mapping a Set of Evaluation Questions Onto a DoView Strategy/Outcomes Diagram Tool (G7) and this will tell you the level of outcomes that a particular evaluation question is focusing on.